

Unit 6 Part B — Writing a One-sided Argumentative Essay (Social Media)

1. Purpose & example questions

Purpose

- To persuade a reader who does not yet agree with you: ONE side of a debatable issue, supported by reasons and examples.
- Never report both sides. The other side appears once only, in the counter-argument paragraph — and it is then defeated.
- Formal throughout, and never “you”: replace it with “teenagers”, “students” or “young people”. An argumentative essay asks the reader to agree; a proposal asks for approval.
- Markers reward three things: relevant content, visible organisation, and accurate wide-ranging language.
- Target audience — the reader named in the question: the editor of the school magazine, your classmates, a debating audience, the general public.

Example questions

Article — “Social media does more harm than good to teenagers.” Write an article for the school magazine arguing for or against this view.

Letter to the editor — “Should schools ban AI chatbots from the classroom?”

Debate speech — “This house believes that social media harms teenagers.”

Online forum post — “Is the internet making us less able to concentrate?”

2. How to plan it — the format for any question

Plan in this order before you write. Every paragraph answers the question, not just the topic.

Part of the essay	What you plan and write — in this order	Word budget
Title	Choose ONE of three patterns: (1) Issue + verdict — Social Media: More Harm Than Good (2) Question — Is Social Media Doing More Harm Than Good? (3) Call to action — Why We Must Rethink Social Media Never “My Opinion About ...” or “Social Media”.	—
Introduction	1. Hook — one striking line, figure, image or short question. Never “Nowadays, social media is very popular.” 2. Narrow the focus — link the issue to teenagers or to our school. 3. Stance — ONE side, in one sentence, never both. Signal: I firmly believe that ... / It is undeniable that ...	≈60 words
Body paragraph 1	1. Topic sentence — a signpost + the argument itself. 2. Explain — build a cause-and-effect chain (X →	≈85 words

	Y → Z), not a list of statements. 3. Example — one named scenario: a Form 5 student, a Tuesday evening, a buzzing group chat. 4. Round off — echo the key words of the question. Signals: <u>First and foremost, ...</u> / <u>The most serious consequence of ... is ...</u>	
Body paragraph 2	Same four moves as Body 1, with a NEW reason — never a repetition in different words. Signals: <u>Moreover, ...</u> / <u>Worse still, ...</u>	≈85 words
Body paragraph 3 (counter-argument & rebuttal)	1. Concede — state the other side fairly: <u>Admittedly, ...</u> / <u>Some may argue that ...</u> 2. Rebut — <u>However, ...</u> + a concrete reason why the objection fails. 3. Re-sharpen — end on your own side, harder than before: <u>What this overlooks is ...</u>	≈100 words
Conclusion	1. Restate the stance in NEW words — do not copy the introduction. 2. Summarise your arguments in one line. 3. Final thought — a recommendation, a warning or a call to action. Signal: <u>The answer is not to ... but to ...</u>	≈55 words
The whole essay in one line: [Stance] → [Argument 1] → [Argument 2] → [Counter + Rebuttal] → [Restate] <i>Word budget: 60 + 85 + 85 + 100 + 55 ≈ 400 words.</i>		

3. Sample writing — the format in action

Question: You have read an article claiming that social media does more harm than good to teenagers. Write an article for the school magazine arguing for OR against this view. Support your view with reasons and examples. (about 400 words)

*Legend — **BOLD** = persuasive language (**RED** = Unit 6 target vocabulary). Underlined = linking words and signals. The right-hand column is the plan that produced each paragraph.*

Social Media: More Harm Than Good Introduction Six hours a day. That is how long the average Hong Kong teenager spends on social media — time that could have been spent sleeping, revising or simply talking to family. Social media is now ubiquitous, and <u>although</u> it promises connection, it quietly reshapes the way young people see themselves and one another. I firmly believe that social media does more harm than good to teenagers. Body 1 — Argument 1 <u>First and foremost</u>, social media is detrimental to teenagers' mental health. Platforms are engineered to reward comparison, <u>so</u> users are inundated with polished photographs of other people's holidays,	The plan behind the sample Title Issue + verdict: Social Media: More Harm Than Good Introduction — 65 words Hook: six hours a day Focus: how teenagers spend that time Stance: the harm outweighs the good Signal: <u>I firmly believe that</u>
--	--

friendships and achievements, and they are **quietly nudged** to measure their own ordinary lives against this fiction. A student who has just failed a test may open her phone and be reminded, within seconds, of a classmate's success. Repeated daily, this comparison **erodes** self-esteem and **exacerbates** the anxiety that many teenagers already carry, and the harm is **insidious** precisely because it **feels so normal**.

Body 2 — Argument 2

Moreover, the damage reaches beyond feelings into academic performance. Every notification leaves attention **fragmented**, and **fragmented** attention makes deep reading — the very skill that public examinations demand — **almost impossible to sustain**. A student who revises with an active group chat is not really revising; she is merely alternating between two tasks and performing both badly. Worse still, late-night scrolling delays sleep, which in turn **undermines** the concentration a student needs in class the next morning.

Body 3 — Counter-argument & rebuttal

Some may argue that social media keeps teenagers connected and gives them a voice they would otherwise lack. Admittedly, a group chat can help a class organise a project, and a student with a niche interest may find an online community that her own school cannot offer. However, these benefits are **superficial** when set against the costs. Connectivity available at every hour of the day is **precisely what makes it so hard to switch off**, and a following built on fleeting likes is rarely **reciprocal** support; it is, **at best**, an **ephemeral** substitute for friendship. To put it bluntly, the convenience is real but modest, while the harm **compounds** year after year.

Conclusion

In conclusion, social media is **not without value**, yet its effects on teenagers' well-being, concentration and self-image **plainly outweigh** its benefits. The answer is not an outright ban, which would be **counterproductive**, but a deliberate effort to **curb** the hours we spend online. If teenagers can learn to switch off, they will discover that the world beyond the screen **deserves their attention**.

(406 words)

Teacher's Note: the sample argues the HARMFUL side. For the opposite stance, keep the same skeleton — concede the harms, rebut with the benefits (access to information, community for isolated students, self-expression) and swap in democratise, indispensable, bolster, conducive, tangible.

Body 1 — 92 words

Topic sentence: detrimental to mental health

Explanation:

comparison → eroding self-esteem → anxiety

Example: a student who has just failed a test

Round off: the harm feels normal

Signal: First and foremost.

Body 2 — 75 words

Topic sentence: the damage reaches academic performance

Explanation: notifications → fragmented attention

→ no deep reading

Example: revising beside a live group chat

Round off: late-night scrolling → poor concentration

Signals: Moreover, / Worse still.

Body 3 — counter-argument & rebuttal — 112 words

Concede: it keeps teenagers connected and gives them a voice

Rebut: the benefits are superficial; constant connectivity is what makes switching off hard

Re-sharpen: the harm compounds year after year

Signals: Some may argue that / Admittedly, / However, / To put it bluntly.

	Conclusion — 62 words Restated stance: the effects outweigh the benefits Summary line: well-being, concentration, self-image Final thought: not a ban, but curbing the hours online Signals: <u>In conclusion</u>, / <u>The answer is not ... but ...</u> Total: 406 words
--	--

4. Language features — five reminders

Both examples in each pair say the SAME thing. **BOLD** = persuasive language. Underlined = linking words.

Reminder	✗ Poor example	✓ Upgraded example (from the sample)
Formal vocabulary <i>no “super”, “stuff”, “a lot of things”</i>	Social media gives teenagers a lot of bad feelings and problems.	Social media exacerbates the anxiety teenagers already carry and erodes their self-esteem .
Passive voice ... be + past participle	Social media shows teenagers perfect lives, and this makes them feel worse.	Teenagers are constantly exposed to polished images of other people’s lives, <u>and</u> their confidence is steadily eroded .
Persuasive language (BOLD)	Social media is bad for students. I think it is a problem.	Social media is detrimental to teenagers’ mental health, and the harm is insidious precisely because it feels so normal .
Linking words (<u>underlined</u>)	Social media is harmful. Students cannot concentrate. Their results are bad.	Social media is harmful; <u>as a result</u> , students can no longer concentrate, <u>and</u> their results suffer .
One side, no “you” and no repeated “I think”	I think you can see that phones are super bad for everyone.	It is undeniable that smartphone dependency undermines students’ concentration, <u>and</u> the consequences are serious .

Teacher’s Tip: project the poor example, let the class fix it aloud, then reveal the upgraded version. The underlined words are the ones that show the marker where the argument is going.

5. Vocabulary upgrade (Unit 6) — keep this page for reference		
	Informal/Basic	Formal
1.	social media is everywhere now	social media is now ubiquitous
2.	it makes the problem worse	it exacerbates / compounds the problem
3.	it slowly damages students' confidence	it erodes students' self-esteem
4.	students get far too much information	students are inundated with posts and notifications
5.	students cannot concentrate on one thing	constant alerts leave students' attention fragmented
6.	the harm is hard to notice at first	the harm is insidious
7.	it is bad for teenagers' health	it is detrimental to teenagers' health
8.	students cannot stop checking their phones	phone-checking has become an unsustainable habit
9.	social media makes us care less about serious things	social media desensitises users to serious issues
10.	the good points are only on the surface	the benefits are superficial and ephemeral
11.	friendships online are not really two-way	friendships online are rarely reciprocal
12.	one rumour can reach thousands of people quickly	a single post can amplify a rumour within minutes
13.	we should limit our screen time	we should curb our screen time
14.	we can use social media for studying	we can harness social media for learning
Unit 6 word	Pattern it takes	Where it appears
ubiquitous (adj)	be ubiquitous among young people / in our daily lives	Introduction
detrimental (adj)	be detrimental to + noun	Body 1
inundate (v)	be inundated with + noun	Body 1
erode (v)	erode + self-esteem / trust / confidence	Body 1
exacerbate (v)	exacerbate + a problem / anxiety	Body 1
insidious (adj)	an insidious effect / an insidious form of harm	Body 1
fragmented (adj)	leave attention / attention span fragmented	Body 2
undermine (v)	undermine + concentration / confidence / trust	Body 2
superficial (adj)	superficial benefits / superficial understanding	Body 3
reciprocal (adj)	reciprocal support / a reciprocal relationship	Body 3
ephemeral	ephemeral fame / an ephemeral	Body 3

(adj)	friendship	
compound (v)	compound + a problem / the pressure on students	Body 3
counterproductive (adj)	be counterproductive / prove counterproductive	Conclusion
curb (v)	curb + screen time / spending / the habit	Conclusion

Other words you may need: proliferate, impede, stifle, jeopardise, perpetuate, alienate, intrusive, conducive, indispensable, bolster, tangible, unsustainable

6. Quick reference — linking words (underlined in the sample)	
<i>Four or five per essay is enough. A linking word must carry an argument, not decorate one.</i>	
When you need to ...	Use one of these
Introduce and take a stance	In recent years, ... has become ubiquitous. I firmly believe that ... It is undeniable that ...
Open the first argument	First and foremost, ... The most serious consequence of ... is ...
Add an argument	Moreover, ... Worse still, ... Equally worrying is ...
Give an example	For instance, ... Consider a Form 5 student who ...
Concede, then rebut	Admittedly, ... Some may argue that ... However, ... What this overlooks is ...
Conclude and end	In conclusion, ... On balance, ... The answer is not to ... but to ...